

3.4.1 Strategies for understanding

3.4.1.1 Ignoring words which are not needed

Many texts contain words which are not essential for an understanding of the main points of the text. Furthermore, what is important in the text is often presented more than once, in different ways: the student may not understand a point in one form of words and understand it fully in another. Students can be trained to read and listen in positive ways, seeking out in the text only the information they need to answer questions and to complete communication tasks and ignoring the rest.

3.4.1.2 Using the visual and verbal context

The skilled reader can find many clues about the purpose and content of a text from a study of the layout, the title, the length, the type-face and any related pictures. This is why texts are presented in the exam in their original format as much as possible. When reading and listening, students can learn to infer the meaning of new words from the verbal context. So, for example, someone who did not know the word *brzoza* could, after some appropriate practice, be expected to understand from the following context that it is some sort of tree: *Usiadł pod brzozą, a na jej czubku siedział ptaszek i śpiewał.*

3.4.1.3 Making use of grammatical markers and categories

Students will be helped to master all these strategies if, when reading and listening, they learn to use such clues as the plural forms of nouns or verbs, the ways verbs change to form tenses, word order and other such features which will help them to recognise to which category (verb, noun, adjective, etc) an unknown word belongs. This can be a considerable help in making intelligent guesses about the meaning of the word.

3.4.1.4 Making use of the social and cultural context

Another aid to correct inferencing is for the students to bear in mind that there are regularities in the real world which will make it possible to anticipate what people must say or write about it. The ability to predict occurrences in the real world makes it possible sometimes to predict the words, and the meaning of words, that represent these occurrences. This is one reason why it is important for a Polish course to offer insights and awareness into the culture and civilisation of Poland and Polish speaking communities like, for example, the very well organised Polish communities in England or America.

3.4.1.5 Using common patterns within Polish

Certain masculine nouns have no feminine counterparts and are used in the masculine form both for men and women.

- *doktor, profesor, inżynier, reżyser, świadek*
- *Profesor Malinowska wyjechała do Anglii.*
 - *Czy świadek widziała pana K?*
 - *Gdzie jest pani doktor?*
- Formation of adjectives from nouns.

This is done by adding the following suffixes to the stem:

- *-ski*
 - *Polska - polski*
 - *Francuz - francuski*
 - *Warszawa - warszawski*
- *-cki*
 - *student - studencki*
 - *Grecja - grecki*
- *-owy*
 - *metal - metalowy*
 - *dom - domowy*
 - *poczta - pocztowy*
- *-ny*
 - *szkoła - szkolny*
 - *nuda - nudny*
 - *trud - trudny*
- *-iczny*
 - *tragedia - tragiczny*
 - *chemik - chemiczny*
 - *geografia - geograficzny*
- *-yczny*:
 - *turysta - turystyczny*
 - *historia - historyczny*
- Formation of opposites of adjectives and adverbs by the addition of *nie-*
 - *dobry - niedobry*
 - *spokojny - niespokojny*
 - *drogo - niedrogo*
 - *długo - niedługo*
- (a) Verbal nouns with the suffix *-anie* are formed from infinitives ending in *-ać*
 - *-ać*
 - *oglądać - oglądanie*
 - *kupować - kupowanie*
 - *na/pisać - na/pisanie*
 - *za/planować - za/planowanie*

(b) Verbal nouns with the suffix *-enie* are formed from infinitives ending in *-eć/ec, -ić/yć*

- *-eć/ec*
 - *zrozumieć - zrozumienie*
 - *piec - pieczenie*
- *-ić/yć*
 - *chodzić - chodzenie*
 - *z/robić - z/robienie*
 - *za/prosić - za/proszenie*
 - *służyć - służenie*

(c) Verbal nouns with the suffix *-cie* are formed from infinitives ending in *-uć, -ić/yć*

- *-uć*
 - *zatruc* - *zatrucie*
 - *zepsuć* - *zepsucie*
- *-ić*
 - *pić* - *picie*
- *-yć*
 - *myć* - *mycie*

(d) Verbal nouns with the suffix *-ęcie* are formed from infinitives ending in *-ąć*

- *ąć*
 - *zamknąć* - *zamknięcie*
 - *przyjąć/przyjęcie*
 - *rozpocząć* - *rozpoczęcie*

(e) Certain verbal nouns have lost their verbal meaning and have become nouns. They are neuter in gender and have plural forms

- *mieszkać* – *mieszkanie/a*
- *zająć* – *zajęcie/a*
- *ćwiczyć* – *ćwiczenie/a*

Suffixes added to known words to form further nouns

- *robota* – *robotnik*
- *trud* – *trudność*
- *śpiew* – *śpiewak*

Suffixes added to nouns to form verbs

- *odpoczynek* – *odpoczywać*
- *przegląd* – *przeglądać*
- *pismo* – *pisać*
- *interes* – *interesować*
- *telefon* – *telefonować*
- Diminutives

Apart from diminutives of proper names like, for example, *Ewa-Ewunia, Jan-Janek, Barbara-Basia, Jerzy-Jurek*, the majority of common nouns may also be used in their diminutive form. It indicates either a small size or is used in intimate conversations. The most common suffixes forming diminutives from basic nouns are the following:

- masculine *-ek* (eg *dom* - *domek, pies* - *piesek, kubek* - *kubeczek*)
- masculine *-ik/yk* (eg *samochód* - *samochodzik, but* - *bucik, stół* - *stolik, strumień* - *strumyk*)
- feminine *-ka* (eg *herbata* - *herbatka, książka* - *książeczka, bajka* - *bajeczka*)
- neuter *-ko* (eg *krzesło* - *krzeselko, mleko* - *mleczko, oko* - *oczko*)

Note that some diminutives have a meaning different from their basic forms or have two meanings:

- *woda* - *wódka*
- *sałata* - *sałatka*
- *biuro* - *biurko*
- *kanapa* - *kanapka*
- *zegar* - *zegarek*

Many adjectives may also be used in diminutive form. The suffix *-utki/a/e* is the most common with adjectival diminutives.

- *mały - malutki*
- *słodka - słodziutka*
- *zgrabne - zgrabniutkie*
- Adjectival compounds denoting colours.

(a) In questions asking for colour, the genitive case is used instead of the nominative.

- *Jakiego koloru jest twoja nowa sukienka?*

In answers to such questions two forms may be used, i.e. nominative or genitive

- *Moja nowa sukienka jest zielona.*
- *Moja nowa sukienka jest zielonego koloru.*

(b) In adjectival compounds denoting two colours, two adjectives indicating colour are used.

The first one has the ending *-o*, the last one ends in *-y*, *-a*, *-e* depending on the gender of the noun being modified. The adjectives are joined by a hyphen.

- *biało-czerwona flaga*
- *szaro-niebieskie niebo*
- *żółto-czarny but*
- The reflexive pronoun *się* with verbs.

(a) Certain verbs are always reflexive, i.e. they are always accompanied by *się*

- *napić się*
- *cieszyć się*
- *bać się*

(b) Some verbs never take *się* in personal forms.

- *czytać*
- *iść*
- *pić*
- *pisać*

(c) The majority of verbs may appear with or without *się*, in which case the presence or absence of *się* changes the meaning of the preceding verb.

- *uczyć - uczyć się*
- *ubierać - ubierać się*
- *przedstawić - przedstawić się*

(d) In a succession of two or more reflexive verbs, the reflexive pronoun *się* is usually not repeated.

- *Tomek denerwuje się i boi.*
- *Janek goli się i myje.*
- Loan words which have a Polish ending or spelling.
- *dżinsy, dżem, menadżer, telewizor, spiker, kemping.*
- Impersonal phrases and sentences.

(a) Words like *wolno*, *warto*, *można*, *trzeba*, *należy* are followed by an infinitive.

- *Czy wolno gotować?*
- *Nie wolno wprowadzać psów.*
- *Można dodać...*

- *Gdzie można umyć ręce?*
- *Trzeba zacząć od...*
- *Nie należy przesadzać.*
- *Warto dodać, że...*
- *Czy warto się tak męczyć?*

(b) Passive participle with the adjectival ending -o, (*mówiono, słyszano*) can also be used in impersonal phrases and sentences.

- *Podano kolację*
- *Co mówiono o Kościuszcze?*
- *Dlaczego nie zbudowano tu lepszej drogi?*
- *Wiele już o tym pisano.*

(c) Some impersonal phrases are often expressed by third person singular or plural.

- *Dużo mówi się o...*
- *Ludzie mówią...*
- *Często słyszy się...*
- Forms of addressing people in Polish.

Young people, friends and relatives address each other in the 2nd person singular. Otherwise *pan/panowie, pani/panie, państwo* are used. *Pani* refers to both married and unmarried women.

After the singular forms (*pan, pani*) a verb in the 3rd person singular is used. After the plural forms (*panowie, panie, państwo*) a verb in the 3rd person plural is used.

- *Czy jesteś zadowolony?*
- *Czy pan jest zadowolony?*
- *Czy pani jest zadowolona?*
- *Czy panowie są zadowoleni?*
- *Czy panie są zadowolone?*
- *Czy państwo są zadowoleni?*

In less formal relations after the forms *panowie, panie, państwo*, a verb in the 2nd person plural is used more and more frequently.

- *Czy panowie jesteście zadowoleni?*
- *Czy panie jesteście zadowolone?*
- *Czy państwo jesteście zadowoleni?*

When addressing a person one should not use the addressee's last name. It is considered bad style. Quite often, however, the word *pan, pani* is followed by the addressee's title or rank. Using a title or rank alone is considered impolite.

- *Czy pan profesor jest zadowolony?*
- *Czy pan dyrektor jest zadowolony?*
- *Czy pani doktor jest zadowolona?*

In more familiar relations the word *pan, pani* may be used followed by the addressee's first name. Both *pan, pani* and the name are used in the vocative.

- *Panie Jurku, czy jest pan zadowolony?*
- *Pani Basiu, czy jest pani zadowolona?*

When addressing a person or attracting somebody's attention the word *pan*, *pani* is preceded by *proszę* or *przepraszam*. Note that after *proszę* the genitive form is used, while after *przepraszam* the accusative is used.

- *Proszę pana, gdzie jest dworzec?*
- *Proszę pani, gdzie jest postój taksówek?*
- *Przepraszam pana, jak dojechać do hotelu?*
- *Przepraszam panią, która godzina?*

Greetings like *dzień dobry* may be followed by *pan*, *pani* which is considered very polite. They are followed by nouns in the dative.

- *Dobry wieczór panu.*
- *Dobranoc paniom.*
- *Dzień dobry państwu.*
- Formation of feminine nouns
- Feminine nouns denoting persons or animals are formed by adding the suffix *-ka*, *-ica*, *-anka*, *-yni* to the masculine noun stem.
 - *-ka*:
 - *kot* - *kotka*
 - *nauczyciel* - *nauczycielka*
 - *ekspedient* - *ekspedientka*
 - *-ica*:
 - *uczeń* - *uczennica*
 - *robotnik* - *robotnica*
 - *siostrzeniec* - *siostrzenica*
 - *-yni*
 - *gospodarz* - *gospodyni*
 - *dozorca* - *dozorczyń*
 - *wychowawca* - *wychowawczyń*
 - *-anka*
 - *kolega* - *koleżanka*
 - *Krakowiak* - *Krakowianka*

3.4.1.6 Using cognates and near-cognates

There are some words, (eg *cylinder*, *nowela*, *karawan*, *argument*, *ekspedient*), whose meanings in Polish and English are totally different and therefore make it necessary to use this strategy with care. However, for every misleading word there are many others of which English speaking learners of Polish can, with practice, make good use. These fall into two main categories.

Cognates

There are very many words which have the same form, and essentially the same meaning, in Polish and in English (eg *anegdota*, *astronauta*, *badminton*, *dieta*, *defekt*, *generał*). When such words occur in a context and learners can be expected to understand them in English, they will be expected also to understand them in Polish.

Near-cognates

Learners will be expected to understand words which meet the criteria above, but which differ slightly in their written form in Polish usually by the addition of one or more Polish characters and/or the repetition, change or withdrawal of letter or letters (eg *ambicja*, *telefon*, *paszport*, *adres*, *akcent*, *apetyt*, *autor*, *bandaż*).

3.4.1.7 Using common patterns between Polish and English

There are some words in Polish, which, although neither cognates or near-cognates, can be easily understood with the application of a few simple rules. When words which can be understood using the rules below occur in context, students will be expected to understand them:

English words ending in '-tion' are sometimes translated into Polish by changing the ending to '-*acja*' (e.g. station - *stacja*, ambition - *ambicja*, situation - *sytuacja*)

English words ending in '-sion' are sometimes translated into Polish by changing the ending to '-*zja*' (eg television - *telewizja*, vision - *wizja*)

There are many words in present-day colloquial and technical Polish which have been taken from English, but given Polish spelling and a Polish ending (eg *leasing*, *dealerzy*, *menadżer*, *komputer*).

It is expected that strategies such as those outlined above will generally be more easily applied in reading than in listening, as reading offers more opportunities to slow down, to look at unknown items at some leisure and to study the context. For the same reasons, use of dictionary is often a more feasible proposition when reading than when listening. However, the general strategies for understanding listed above can, with practice, be used successfully in listening to Polish. In order to hear accurately, candidates should have the relationship between the spoken and written language brought to their attention. Words which look the same in Polish and English may sound different and conversely, words with similar sounds may be written very differently in the two languages.